

Tips and tactics for tighter security

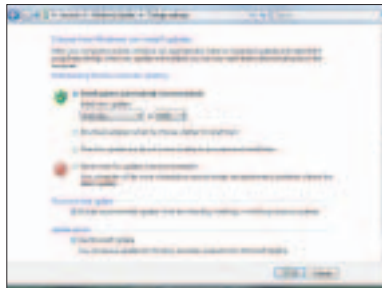
We show you how to improve the safety of your Vista PC with some lesser-known tweaks

As Windows users, we sometimes get a hard time from users of other operating systems about security. It's not really fair, especially since Microsoft has made many improvements in this area for Windows Vista. That's not to say that Vista is perfect — there's still no built-in anti-virus and one or two other areas need to be tightened up with third-party software but now you get plenty of protection from the moment Vista is installed.

The key to a strong defence is knowing how to get the most from Vista's built-in tools, and knowing when to start looking farther afield for replacement and/or substitute security utilities from other sources. With that in mind, here are a few cunning ways to ramp up your PC's protection.

Tip 1

Keeping up to date with the latest security fixes is an essential part of staying safe. Vista includes a tool called Windows Update for this purpose and it should be set to look for updates automatically. It also can check for updates for other Microsoft software. Left-



click on the Start button and then on Control Panel. Click on 'Check for updates' in the Security section in the left-hand column. While there, click on the 'Check for updates' link and follow the instructions to download any available updates. Then click on the Change Settings link and make sure the top option is selected to install updates automatically. Select the bottom option 'Use Microsoft Update' to include other Microsoft

software when looking for updates. Click on OK. You may need to click on Continue or enter your password for User Account Control (UAC).

Tip 2

Checking for updates to Microsoft software is automatic, but what about software from non-Microsoft sources, such as Nero, Adobe or Roxio? Some applications have built-in update-checking tools but others don't. There's a useful utility called Secunia PSI that scans the software



installed on the computer and compares it with a list of recent versions. This can be found on our cover disc or downloaded from <https://psi.secunia.com>. Once installed, this will scan the computer for software that needs updating or is no longer supported. It does not download any updates itself although it does include links to update pages on the internet for some software. It remains in the Notification Area and will periodically display reminders when software needs updating.

Tip 3

Though the Windows Firewall often gets a bad press, there are important things in its favour. First, it is active as soon as Windows starts and it will block all inbound internet communication until Windows Update has done its checks. As many attacks are initiated from these inbound connections it can be a good idea to block them entirely if the network cannot be trusted. To do this, click on the

